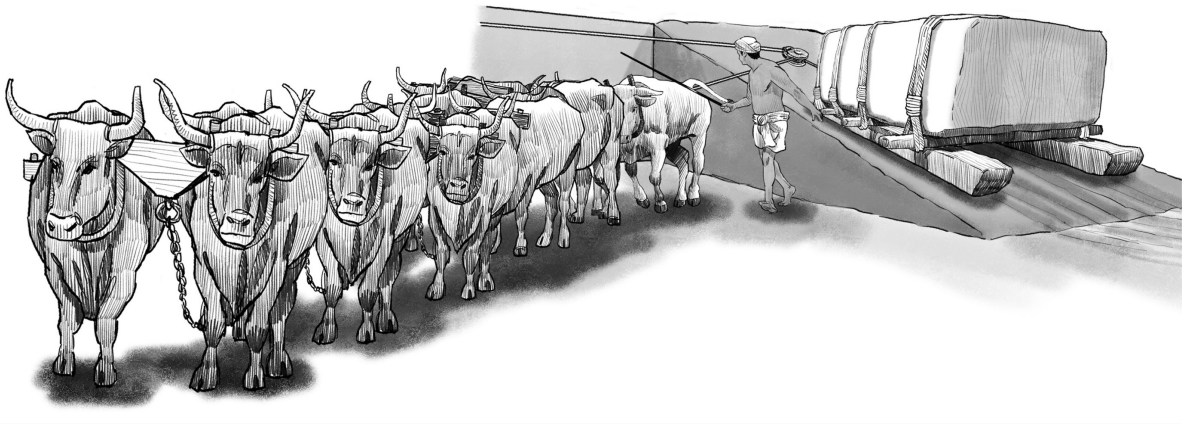


Once the marble reached the site, it was too heavy to be lifted by the workers. Instead, ramps of earth were built, and workers used ropes with pulleys to drag the heavy stone to the topmost level under construction. Probably oxen and even elephants were used to help. It is thought that the dome of the Taj Mahal alone weighs more than twelve thousand tons. That is equal to about twenty-five jet airliners.



Hundreds of skilled masons were called on to fit the stones together. The masons smoothed the places where each stone met another. Their work was so precise that a historian of the time wrote that no one could see “any cracks between [the stones].” In some parts of the monument, red sandstone was used. Afterward, the masons covered the sandstone with white marble.

In June 1632, a year after Mumtaz died, a memorial service called an *Urs* was held at the construction site. From then on, each year on the anniversary of her death, an Urs took place. It was a way to honor the memory of Mumtaz and keep her alive in the minds of the people.

The occasion was somber but very lavish. Tents were raised in the gardens. On carpets inside, people could enjoy food, beverages, and sweets. Spices and perfumes freshened the air.